

Reading Response Paper 3

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For starters, in Carl Mitcham's "Historical Traditions in the Philosophy of Technology", he brought to light a few distinct contemporary definitions of technology. The first definition was by Singer who defined technology as "how things are commonly done or made [and] what things are commonly done or made" [Mitcham 1979]. This definition is slightly problematic in the sense that there isn't much room for things that are not considered technology. Mitcham points out that this definition would consider politics and making of laws as technology which some might disagree with. Another questionable inclusion is actions such as walking or breathing would be considered technology as they are things that are commonly done. As such, people have problems this definition of technology due to its overly inclusive nature.

On the other hand, Kranzberg and Pursell who defined technology as the human "effort to cope with [the] physical environment ... and [the] attempts to subdue or control the environment by means of ... imagination and ingenuity in the use of all available resources" [Mitcham 1979]. Additionally, Kranzberg and Pursell add a second definition (which Mitcham argues contradicts their first) that technology is "nothing more than the area of interactions between ourselves, as individuals, and our environment, whether material or spiritual, natural or man-made" [Mitcham 1979]. These two definitions clearly limit technology to only things to do with nature, which isn't much of a limitation, but the second definition would more clearly include things such as religious structures and monuments whereas the first one would not necessarily include this.

Another definition from Mitcham's text was by Maurice Daumas who limited technology to "only those human activities whose object is to collect, adapt, and transform raw material in order to improve the conditions of human existence" [Mitcham 1979]. Mitcham points out that this does not include things such as military technologies such as nuclear weaponry.

In class, we did an exercise, lead by Vivian, that asked groups of students to define technology. My group decided on the definition of technology as human made artifacts that are used to improve a process / quality of life or create a new means of doing something. This definition is similar to the Daumas definition however it is not limited to only the technologies that affect the environment. However, one could make the argument that this definition does not include any sort of technologies not man made such as say beaver dams. Additionally, due to the "artifact" parameter there is also the argument against any sort of theoretical technologies such as mathematics and calculus.

Works Cited

Carl Mitcham, "Techne and Technology." in *Historical Traditions in the Philosophy of Technology*, 116-134.